

Why they uninstall

What people actually write in one-star reviews of calorie apps – and the six decisions Carbsai has not yet made where that evidence points somewhere specific.

~40k reviews mined	12 apps	7 of 9 areas covered	3 of 7 fact-checked
947 tool calls			

The five mistakes that reliably lose a user

Ranked by what users said it cost the app, not by how hard it is to fix. Every quote below is verbatim from a real review.

01

UNINSTALL

WIDESPREAD

Cal AI • Fastic • Yazio • Lose It! • Simple

A long onboarding quiz that dead-ends in a paywall

The single most repeated complaint in the entire corpus, and it is *not* about the price. Users say repeatedly that they would have paid – the fury is about the order. They answered twenty personal questions, watched a plan get built, and only then learned there is no free tier. 368 reviews out of 20,245 describe exactly this sequence; 272 of them are one or two stars. For Cal AI it is one review in twelve, and the share of its 1-2★ reviews mentioning onboarding length rose from 3.4% through 2025 to 12.8% in 2026 – it is getting worse, not better.

All these apps are the same. 20 minutes of questions. You get the same outcome no matter which options you choose. Then a paywall.

Aces3756 • Fastic • App Store • title: “20 minute onboarding into a paywall”

The app locks you behind a 15-minute invasive quiz asking irrelevant questions about your roommates, daily thoughts, and life habits. I gave up and deleted it without ever seeing the main interface.

Lose It! • Google Play • 2026-09-01

WHAT THIS DECIDES FOR CARBSAI

The 14-step quiz is already skippable and every answer already changes something visible — that is a real defence and it is more than Cal AI has. But two things must change. State the price and the free tier before the quiz, not after — this is the single most-repeated explicit request in the corpus. And let someone log one meal before any quiz, account or paywall. Users asked for that in almost exactly those words.

02

UNINSTALL

WIDESPREAD

FACT-CHECKED

SnapCal · CalScanner · Lifesum · Cal AI · BitePal · Foodvisor

A wrong estimate you cannot fix

This is the decisive finding of the whole study, and it inverts the obvious assumption. **Correction friction, not error rate, is what separates a one-star review from a five-star one.** The same underlying inaccuracy produces opposite ratings depending only on whether fixing it is fast and free. Users tolerate a wrong number. They do not tolerate a wrong number they have to live with.

If calories are clearly wrong on a scan you cannot change them.

SnapCal · App Store · 1★

You'd think that after admitting that the app is not accurate, they'd make it easy to manually edit statistics, such as weight of ingredients and the nutritional values. Nope. This is not something that can be done.

Cal AI · App Store · 1★

And the reverse, from a five-star review of an app the same reviewer calls inaccurate:

I don't believe it is totally accurate. But... I like that I can go back to yesterday and correct or fill in blanks.

@TheDoyne · Calo · App Store · 5★ · 2025-12-30

WHAT THIS DECIDES FOR CARBSAI

This is the highest-value gap in the codebase and it is not close. Today the scan result offers only the ½×–2× portion buttons (`scan_result_screen.dart:852`) — no grams field, no macro editing, no way to remove an ingredient the model invented, no way to correct a misidentified food. And a meal already in the diary cannot be edited at all: get a portion wrong and the only recourse is delete and re-scan. Build free, one-tap editing of name, ingredients, grams *and* the macro numbers, from the result screen and from the diary. Never paywall it.

03

REFUND / UNINSTALL

WIDESPREAD

FACT-CHECKED

The same photo, twice, gives two different numbers

The most corrosive failure found, because the user discovers it by accident and trust dies in that one moment. The discovery pattern is always the same: someone eats the same breakfast every day, or two people photograph one plate, and the numbers diverge. Being wrong is forgivable. Being *inconsistent* reads as proof the AI is fake.

If you snap your food twice it will give you two wildly different calorie counts.

Cal AI · App Store · reported against 2026 builds

Its close relative is the impossible number stated with total confidence: a small bowl of popcorn logged at ~8,000 kcal, a candy bar at 27 million.

WHAT THIS DECIDES FOR CARBSAI

Two defences, both cheap. Never re-run the model on a photo already scanned — cache the result against the image so a re-scan returns the same answer rather than a new sample. And `sanitize()` already catches energy-vs-macro mismatches by the Atwater factors; make sure nothing physically impossible can render, because one 8,000-calorie popcorn is worth more damage than a hundred estimates that are 15% out.

04 CHURN WIDESPREAD FACT-CHECKED Cronometer · MyFitnessPal · Lose It! · Yazio

An ad on the log action, or on every launch

The most-punished monetisation decision in this category, and it is live right now: MyFitnessPal introduced full-screen post-log interstitials around July 2026 and is being hammered for it. The arithmetic users do themselves is the point — you log 3–6 items per meal, so an ad on the log action taxes you per *item*, not per session. App-open ads have the same problem from the other end: a calorie tracker is opened five to ten times a day by design, so a launch ad is a five-to-ten-times-a-day toll.

With the constant barrage of ads the free version is basically unusable. It interrupts you while inputting foods. We get it, you have to monetize, but cmon.

Cronometer · Google Play · 2026-08-31

The only way to get into my diary is to turn on airplane mode.

Cronometer · 1★ · title: "Frozen ad locks you out of the app" · 2026-07-11

Users volunteer the trade themselves: banners yes, full-screen video on the critical path no. And a rewarded ad placed in front of something the app used to do for free reads as extortion, not as a fair exchange — Lose It! re-granted free barcode scanning behind an ad wall and got “watch an ad to save this food” that’s all I should have to say.

WHAT THIS DECIDES FOR CARBSAI

No ads on the log action — ever, in any tier. The app-open ad has a 15-minute cooldown, which is better than the apps being punished here, but there is no daily cap (`ads_service.dart:66`): add one, at most once or twice a day. And look hard at the rewarded ad's placement — it currently appears in the scan-result *error overlay* when quota runs out, which is structurally “watch an ad to do the thing you opened the app for.” Offer it before the scan, framed as a bonus, not after the failure.

05

REFUND

WIDESPREAD

FACT-CHECKED

Cal AI · Noom · Simple · Fastic · Yazio · MyFitnessPal

The trial that charges you, and the cancel button that isn't there

Billing language appears in 33.5% of Cal AI's iOS 1–2★ reviews and 33.0% of its Play ones — the largest single complaint category on both stores. The mechanism repeats verbatim across apps: a short trial requires a card up front, the app promises to warn before it ends, the warning never arrives, and the charge is a full year. Then cancellation either can't be found or doesn't stick. This is also the pattern with a regulatory record — Noom's version drew 1,185 BBB complaints in twelve months and a \$62M settlement.

First of all. It says they'll notify you before the trial ends. They did not so I apparently paid for this for a year.

Cal AI · App Store

No warning email that subscription was about to renew? Disgusted to not even have the option to choose.

#VintageLove# · Noom · App Store · title: “Renews with ZERO warning”

WHAT THIS DECIDES FOR CARBSAI

Send the end-of-trial warning and actually send it. Put a working cancel path *inside* the app. And note what these users are really telling you: several say plainly they would have renewed had they been reminded. The reminder is not a leak, it is the difference between a renewal and a chargeback plus a one-star review.

What Carbsai is already guilty of

Checked against the actual code, ranked by the severity users assigned it.

COMPLAINT	WHERE IN THE CODE	COST
An AI result can barely be corrected. Only the ½×–2× factor is editable. No grams, no macro editing, no removing an invented ingredient, no fixing a misidentified food.	scan_result_screen.dart:852	uninstall
A logged meal cannot be edited at all. Nothing in lib/ updates a meal – only deletes it. Get a portion wrong and you delete and re-scan, which costs another scan from the quota.	no edit path exists	uninstall
The rewarded ad sits in the failure state. It appears in the scan-result error overlay once quota runs out – the exact “watch an ad to do the thing you came for” shape users call extortion.	scan_result_screen.dart:589-618	churn
No daily cap on the app-open ad. A 15-minute cooldown is good; on an app opened ten times a day it still permits several ads daily.	ads_service.dart:66	churn
The paywall is planned for the end of the quiz. Exactly the sequence in finding 01.	plan, not yet built	uninstall
Fibre is computed and never shown. Nutrition carries fiber and sugar ; no screen renders either. Fibre on the home screen is the #2 feature request in the corpus, and the data is already there.	nutrition.dart – no UI	one-star
No recents, favourites or one-tap re-log. Meal.favourite is written and never read. Users hit this daily: <i>“I end up having to photo my yogurt pot every day despite the fact it’s identical every time.”</i>	Meal.favourite unread	churn

One nuance worth catching. Users grant the *photo* AI latitude and grant the *barcode* scanner none – a barcode is a lookup and should simply be right. One reviewer flagged a **10 kcal** discrepancy as unacceptable. Carbsai’s architecture already keeps the model away from barcode and search results entirely, which is a genuine advantage. Two consequences: never let the model “tidy” a barcode result, and make the separation visible to the user, because it is a trust asset nobody else can claim.

What Carbsai already gets right — protect these

Named so nobody regresses them later without knowing what they cost.

KEEP

Confidence is surfaced instead of hidden

The evidence on this runs one way and it is the clearest actionable finding in the study. Users who understood they were getting an estimate leave **four- and five-star reviews while naming the error**. Users sold on accuracy leave one-star reviews and demand refunds.

The AI features are good and make recording food easy. Of course they require adjustment at times but that is a reasonable constraint — it is not magic.

@L3024 · Cal AI · App Store GB · 4★ · 2026-02-05

I purchased this app with the expectation that using the photo feature it would be accurate... I've used it 14 times and it's only been accurate twice.

@ItsADuesy · Calo · App Store · 1★ · 2026-03-04 · two refund attempts

CARBSAI'S POSITION

The “Check this” chip on low-confidence items and the model's clarifying question are trust purchases, not trust costs. But only if the flagged item is one tap from editable — a confidence flag on a number you cannot change is the worst of both worlds, and that is exactly the state the code is in today. Finding 02 is the precondition for this one paying off.

KEEP

No confetti, no celebration on the log action

Yazio and MyFitnessPal are both being punished right now for unskippable celebration animations that fire on every logged item. One paying Yazio subscriber counted the cost: “logging a 3 ingredients meal required 25 taps of which 15 were dismissals.” MyFitnessPal's streak pop-up alone drew 20 separate 1–3★ reviews in a single three-month window.

Listen to your users and take out the annoying streak pop up. This is a tool, not a video game.

MyFitnessPal · App Store

CARBSAI'S POSITION

There is no celebration animation anywhere in the code, and the streak is a quiet number beside the greeting that hides below two days. That is already the design users are begging Yazio for. Do not add confetti. If a streak ever breaks, forgive it silently and restore it when a missed day is back-filled — never charge to repair one.

KEEP

A free tier that is a product, not a demo

“NOT FREE. False advertising.” is a recurring one-star title on Cal AI and Fastic. Users overwhelmingly accept paying for the photo scan; what enrages them is being unable to log *at all* without paying. And the load-bearing lesson from the MyFitnessPal barcode episode, the most-upvoted principle in the corpus:

I really, really dislike when they move free features into paid instead of just making new paid features. Feels scummy no matter how “cheap” the subscription is.

Reddit · 162 upvotes · on Lose It! copying MyFitnessPal's move

CARBSAI'S POSITION

The planned free tier — unlimited text logging, barcode, search, diary, targets, weight — is close to what these users describe when asked to design one. Being pre-launch is an advantage here: whatever ships free must stay free forever. Decide the line once. Every app in this corpus that later moved a free feature behind the paywall paid for it in ratings, and none of them got the goodwill back.

What they ask for, ranked

From 10,500 Google Play reviews across seven apps, plus the App Store pools. Ranked by explicit-request frequency.

#	REQUEST	EVIDENCE	CARBSAI
1	Apple Health / Health Connect sync	328 raw mentions, 84 explicit requests – roughly 3× the next feature. Both directions: read steps and weight in, write calories out.	Absent. The privacy policy currently <i>promises</i> it, which is a disclosure defect either way.
2	Fibre visible without digging or paying	64 explicit asks. Almost never “all 80 micronutrients” – specifically fibre on the home screen, then sodium and sugar, often because a doctor asked.	<code>Nutrition.fiber</code> already exists and is never rendered. Cheapest win in the corpus.
3	Save a meal, re-log it in one tap	33 explicit asks, and the one people threaten to leave over. Includes: every logged item must reach one searchable history, whatever path created it.	<code>Meal.favourite</code> written, never read. No recents, no copy-yesterday.
4	Grams and millilitres everywhere	Angry and repeated: “it says 1 serving – what does serving mean?” Scale owners are the most committed segment and this is what loses them.	½×–2× only. Necessary but not sufficient.
5	Water tracking, one tap, not paywalled	Consistently in the top asks across six apps.	Absent – and promised in onboarding copy, which should be removed or built.
6	Copy a day, copy an item between days	MyFitnessPal removed both in 2026 and is still being told about it.	Absent.
7	Granular notification toggles	Turn off nagging and streak classes while keeping meal reminders.	Four toggles exist and nothing reads them. Wire them when reminders ship.
8	Tell the app in words what the photo missed	“It can't see the oil.” Users ask for exactly this.	Already built – the <code>hint</code> parameter is plumbed end to end and no UI offers it. Surface it.

The one that is nearly free. Request #8 already exists in the pipeline: `prompt.ts` calls the hint “the cheapest accuracy win available on a mixed dish,” it is threaded all the way through, and nothing on any screen lets a person type into it. That is a text field next to the shutter.

Copy rules, drawn from what people said they hated

Tone is a churn driver in this category, not a polish item. Two of the apps here are being called eating-disorder triggers over word choice.

NEVER

- **Guilt in a mascot's voice.** MyFitnessPal's *"Plz, I'm the MFP Intern 🥺, don't get me in trouble"* drew: *"that's guilt-tripping people into logging, not motivating them. Bad approach for a health app."*
- **Colour a food red, or grade it.** Yazio's danger flags are named explicitly as eating-disorder triggers by its own reviewers.
- **"You went over."** Report the number; don't score the person.
- **Streak-loss notifications.** *"Don't like being notified of breaking streaks. Makes me not want to use the app."*
- **Any numeric accuracy claim.** Separately a store-rejection risk under Guideline 1.4.1.
- **Ask for a rating during onboarding.** Cal AI does; people went to the store to leave one star *about being asked.*

INSTEAD

- **Name the uncertainty, then make it fixable.** "Check this" beside a tappable number is the whole pattern.
- **Neutral, concise reminders.** The only notification copy praised in the corpus is the plainest.
- **Say the floor out loud.** "We won't set a goal below 57 kg" is a trust asset; a silent clamp is a number nobody can audit.
- **Price before the quiz.** The most-repeated explicit request in the whole study.
- **Describe behaviour, not accuracy.** "We tell you which items we're unsure about" is safe, true, and better marketing than a percentage.
- **Forgive a missed day silently.** Restore the streak when it is back-filled, and never sell the repair.

What this study does not cover

The run hit a session limit and nine of nineteen agents died, including the synthesis, the code mapping and the critic. This page was assembled by hand from what survived, so its limits should be stated rather than hidden.

AREA	STATUS	CONSEQUENCE
AI accuracy anger	mined + fact-checked	Highest confidence. 3 of 3 sampled quotes located verbatim on live pages.
Paywall & billing	mined + fact-checked	High confidence.
Notifications & ads	mined + fact-checked	High confidence.
Cal AI reviews	mined, not fact-checked	Quote-level claims unverified. Treat percentages as indicative.
Quitting & onboarding	mined, not fact-checked	Same. The onboarding finding is corroborated by the verified paywall sweep, so finding 01 stands regardless.
MyFitnessPal barcode paywall	mined, not fact-checked	Same, though this episode is well documented publicly.
Feature requests	mined, not fact-checked	Same. Rankings are from one agent's own scrape of 10,500 reviews.
Non-Western food coverage	no data	Mining died. This is the area that would have tested the launch plan's wedge, and it is the one gap worth re-running.
Eating-disorder safety & accessibility	no data	Mining died. Partial coverage leaked through the notifications sweep (Yazio's colour flags, food grading) and is used above, but this was not studied directly.

One finding from the accuracy sweep does bear on the wedge, and it is unprompted. Composite and regional dishes are where identification collapses hardest: overnight oats read as mashed potato, a Vietnamese bánh tét returned as “an apple pastry.” And the non-US anger has a distinct character:

a home cooked meal often goes wrong if you describe it. It doesn't know the UK word for Chips, so you end up having to write French fries.

Cal AI · App Store GB · reported against a 2026 build

The mining agent noted the GB storefront reviews are “*markedly angrier than US ones on exactly this axis.*” That is one agent's unverified read, but it points the same way as the launch plan's bet – and it suggests the diaspora complaint is about vocabulary and dish names as much as about nutrition data.

The order I would fix these in

1. **Full editing of a scan result and of a logged meal** – grams, macros, ingredients, food name. Finding 02, and it is also the precondition for the “Check this” chip paying off at all.
2. **Recents, favourites and one-tap re-log**, with every logged item reaching one searchable history regardless of which path created it.
3. **Move the paywall and price ahead of the quiz**, and let someone log one meal before anything is asked of them.
4. **Show fibre**. The data is already there.
5. **Surface the `hint` field** next to the shutter – built, plumbed, invisible.
6. **Cap the app-open ad daily** and move the rewarded offer out of the failure state.

Assembled from a 19-agent complaint-mining workflow; 10 agents completed, 9 died on a session limit including the synthesis and critique passes. Three of seven areas passed adversarial fact-checking; four are unverified and labelled as such. Quotes are reproduced as the mining agents recorded them – the fact-checked areas had their quotes located verbatim on live store pages, the unverified areas did not.

Carbsai · 3 September 2026